SAP LEAD / THE PRACTICE EDITION

Leadership Toolkit

Decisions, people and delivery in SAP situations

A practical print-first guide to responsibility, conflict, delegation, delivery risk and clear decisions across SAP teams.

10 cases / RACI & DACI / Methods & B2 spoken answers

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NAVIGATION / PRINT REFERENCE

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START HERE

How to use this guide

Practise judgement, not management vocabulary. Choose a technique only if it changes the next action.

Read	Understand the difference between responsibility and decision authority.
Speak	Answer one fictional situation aloud in about 90 seconds.
Handle pressure	Reply to the challenge; then change a condition and reconsider.
Review	Compare your answer against ownership, risks and proof.

A Lead answer in five moves

Move	Question	Useful evidence
Outcome	What must the business protect?	Missed delivery, blocked order, financial control
Evidence	What do we know?	Document flow, test, interface trace
Authority	Who decides and who executes?	RACI, DACI or change record
Trade-off	Which choice fits the constraints?	Time, scope, risk and maintenance
Close	What confirms success?	Owner, date, criteria and evidence

All scenarios are fictional. SAP behaviour and approval authority vary by project and system.

PART I / OWNERSHIP

Responsibility and decision rights

RACI defines work ownership. DACI defines who drives and approves one decision. Both may be needed, but they are not interchangeable.

Four RACI roles

Role	Meaning	Question to ask
R — Responsible	Does the work and produces the deliverable. One or more people can contribute, but the task must not become ownerless.	Who will actually prepare, test, or fix it?
A — Accountable	Owns the outcome and accepts or signs off the work within their authority. Use one A for each row.	Who is answerable if this deliverable is not ready?
C — Consulted	Gives input before work is completed or approved. This is a two-way conversation.	Whose expertise or agreement must shape the work?
I — Informed	Receives relevant updates or the result, without another approval round.	Who needs to know the outcome?

RACI and DACI compared

Question	RACI	DACI
What does it organise?	Tasks, handoffs and deliverable ownership.	One choice that needs analysis and approval.
Who is key?	Responsible person and one Accountable owner per deliverable.	Driver who moves the decision and Approver who closes it.
SAP example	Who prepares mapping, executes tests and signs off evidence?	Should the order interface use an API, IDoc or event-based integration?
What does it not solve?	The technical design, conflicting objectives or the overall go/no-go authority.	Who will do every delivery task after the decision.

> Use one Accountable owner for each deliverable, and one authorised Approver for the decision.

OWNERSHIP / WORKED EXAMPLE

RACI in an SAP project

An illustrative responsibility matrix for SAP Order-to-Cash testing and cutover.

Deliverable	Business owner	SD Lead	Integration Lead	Test Lead	Release Manager
Agree business acceptance criteria	A	R	C	C	I
Validate sales-order interface mapping	I	C	A / R	C	I
Prepare end-to-end test data	C	R	C	A	I
Execute business UAT and log evidence	A	C	C	R	I
Assess business acceptance of open defects	A	C	C	R	C
Publish the cutover checklist	C	C	C	C	A / R

R = Responsible / A = Accountable / C = Consulted / I = Informed

Read the matrix

For test data, the SD Lead prepares it and the Test Lead owns readiness. The business and Integration teams provide input. The Release Manager receives the status.

Apply it in 15 minutes

List deliverables	Start with five to ten important outcomes.
Assign ownership	Exactly one A and at least one R for each row.
Confirm evidence	Agree the criteria that prove the result.
Escalate gaps	Escalate an unclear decision boundary, not a person.

PART II / FIELD REFERENCE

Leadership methods

Ten common situations. Use the lightest technique that creates a clear decision or better commitment.

METHOD 01 / DECISIONS

Make ownership visible before debating options.

Many “technical disagreements” are really authority problems. We first define who drives the analysis, who decides, who contributes, and who only needs the outcome.

Technique	Use it when	Practical move / SAP example
RACI	A delivery task falls between workstreams.	For each deliverable, agree who does the work, who owns the outcome, who is consulted, and who is informed. Example: Assign ownership of UAT data, interface checks, and cutover evidence.
DACI	A cross-team decision keeps circling.	Name one Driver and one Approver. Contributors advise; Informed receive the decision. Example: Choosing API, IDoc, or event for a new order integration.
Decision record	The choice will be challenged later.	Write context, options, decision, reasons, assumptions, risks, owner, and revisit trigger. Example: Why we accepted a temporary side-by-side extension before a clean-core replacement.
Reversible vs. hard-to-reverse	The team is over-analysing every choice.	Spend more evidence and senior attention on decisions that are expensive to undo. Example: A field label can move quickly; an enterprise BP numbering design cannot.
Pre-mortem	A plan looks suspiciously clean.	Assume the initiative failed. Ask what caused it. Convert the strongest causes into controls and owners. Example: Before cutover, imagine billing failed for the first business day and trace likely causes.

METHOD 02 / CONFLICT

Do not fight positions. Find the interests behind them.

“We need custom code” and “we need clean core” are positions. The useful conversation is about speed, risk, upgrade cost, ownership, controls, and what must be true for each option to work.

Technique	Use it when	Practical move / SAP example
Interests → options → criteria	Two stakeholders defend incompatible solutions.	Write what each side is protecting, create several options, then compare them against agreed criteria. Example: Trying to compromise before understanding the real constraints.
BATNA	A negotiation has a hard boundary.	Know what we will do if no agreement is reached. It prevents accepting a worse deal only to end tension. Example: Threatening with a weak or imaginary alternative.
Steelman first	The discussion has become tribal.	State the strongest version of the other side's argument before answering it. Example: Repeating a caricature and calling it alignment.
Escalate the decision, not the emotion	The team cannot close the issue at its authority level.	Escalate options, evidence, trade-offs, recommendation, and deadline. Example: Escalating people as "difficult" instead of escalating a blocked decision.

METHOD 03 / FEEDBACK

Describe what happened. Do not diagnose the person.

Vague feedback creates defence. Specific feedback creates something we can work with.

Technique	Use it when	Practical move / SAP example
SBI / SBII	Situation → observable Behaviour → Impact → ask about Intent.	"In today's design review, when the test concern was cut off twice, we lost the evidence we needed for approval. What were you trying to achieve in that moment?"
Feed-forward	After the fact is clear, define the next behaviour.	"For the next review, bring the risk and your proposed mitigation in the first five minutes."
Positive specificity	Reinforce behaviours worth repeating, not personality labels.	"You separated data, config, and interface hypotheses before testing. That shortened the diagnosis."

METHOD 04 / DELEGATION

Delegate a result and a boundary.

If every decision returns to the Lead, we have distributed tasks but kept all ownership. That does not scale.

Technique	Use it when	Practical move / SAP example
Investigate	Collect facts and options.	Lead decides.

Technique	Use it when	Practical move / SAP example
Recommend	Analyse and propose a decision.	Lead approves or challenges.
Decide within guardrails	Own the decision inside defined cost, risk, architecture, or timeline limits.	Lead reviews exceptions, not every step.
Own outcome	Deliver the result and keep stakeholders aligned.	Lead checks evidence and system health.

METHOD 05 / MOTIVATION

Motivation is usually a system problem before it is a speech problem.

We look at whether people can make meaningful choices, become better at the work, see why it matters, experience fair treatment, and notice progress.

Technique	Use it when	Practical move / SAP example
Autonomy	Give a real decision boundary.	Every small choice needs permission.
Competence	Match challenge with support, review, and learning.	The same person receives only easy work or impossible work.
Purpose	Connect work to a business outcome.	The team only hears ticket numbers and deadlines.
Fairness	Make workload, recognition, and expectations explainable.	Invisible work always lands on the same people.
Progress	Make completed outcomes visible.	Long programmes feel like permanent incompletion.

METHOD 06 / PLANNING

Plan what we know, expose what we assume.

A date is not a plan. A useful plan shows deliverables, dependencies, capacity, uncertainty, risk, owners, and the next decisions.

Technique	Use it when	Practical move / SAP example
Backward planning	Cutover, assessment, release, milestone.	Start from the proof of done and work backward through prerequisites.

Technique	Use it when	Practical move / SAP example
Critical dependency map	Cross-team delivery.	Track the few dependencies that can block the outcome, with owners and needed-by dates.
Assumption log	Early estimates and architecture work.	If an estimate depends on something unproven, write it as an assumption with a validation date.
Risk = probability × impact, then action	Prioritising attention.	The score is not the work. Every material risk needs mitigation, contingency, owner, and trigger.
Buffer by uncertainty	Plans with discovery or external dependencies.	Do not hide uncertainty inside every task. Make contingency visible at the appropriate level.

METHOD 07 / REPORTING

Report for a decision, not for decoration.

Senior stakeholders rarely need all activity. They need to know whether the outcome is moving, what changed, what can hurt it, and where they must decide.

Technique	Use it when	Practical move / SAP example
Outcome	What moved since the last report?	Accepted process, passed test, closed defect class, completed migration object.
Forecast	What do we expect now?	Date or range with confidence and assumptions.
Risk	What could change the forecast?	Dependency, defect trend, decision delay, capacity, data quality.
Decision needed	What must someone decide?	Options, recommendation, consequence of delay, decision date.
Evidence	Why should the reader trust the status?	Test result, reconciliation, throughput, defect ageing, signed decision.

METHOD 08 / MEETINGS

A meeting should earn the time it consumes.

Use synchronous time for disagreement, decisions, problem solving, coordination, and difficult human conversations. Move simple status transfer into written updates.

Technique	Use it when	Practical move / SAP example
Decision meeting	Send context and options before the call. Start with the decision question.	Decision, owner, conditions, actions.
Working session	Bring the artefact: process, design, test evidence, data, or incident timeline.	Changed artefact, not just discussion notes.
Daily coordination	Focus on blockers, dependencies, and next handoffs.	Re-plan where needed.
1:1	Use the time for context, feedback, development, load, and concerns that do not belong in a group meeting.	Clarity and follow-up, not surveillance.

METHOD 09 / SELF

Protect judgment before protecting busyness.

A Lead becomes a bottleneck when every message feels urgent and every problem receives immediate personal attention.

Technique	Use it when	Practical move / SAP example
Control / influence / observe	Separate what we can change now, what we can influence, and what we only need to monitor.	“What is the next action inside our control?”
WIP limit	Limit simultaneous deep problems. Finish or delegate before opening another.	“Which current commitment should stop if this becomes priority?”
Timebox analysis	Set a point when investigation must produce either evidence, escalation, or a new hypothesis.	“What will we know after 60 minutes that we do not know now?”
Decision journal	Record important assumptions and expected outcomes.	“Was the decision bad, or did an uncertain outcome go against us?”
Recovery margin	Keep some unscheduled capacity for incidents, reviews, and hard conversations.	“If the week is already at 100%, where will real problems go?”

METHOD 10 / LEARNING

Fix the system without removing accountability.

Blame hides information. No accountability hides repeated behaviour. We need both a safe investigation and clear ownership for improvements.

Technique	Use it when	Practical move / SAP example
After Action Review	What did we expect? What happened? Why was there a gap? What will we change?	Small set of owned improvements.
5 Whys with evidence	Why did this condition exist? What evidence supports the next “why”?	Contributing causes, not a convenient single culprit.
Countermeasure test	Would this action have prevented or detected the failure earlier?	Controls tied to the failure mechanism.
Reusable memory	What should the next team know without rediscovering it?	Runbook, check, design rule, monitoring signal, or decision record.

PART III / CASEBOOK

Situation practice

Read one story, speak for 90 seconds, then respond to the assessor. Do not read the model answer before your attempt.

Identify the business result.

Separate facts from assumptions.

Compare possible decisions and the risk.

Name the owner and evidence of completion.

CASE 01 / RACI · OWNERSHIP

The UAT handoff nobody owns

THE SITUATION

Two weeks before user acceptance testing, the business expects the SAP SD team to create realistic orders. The SD team expects the test team to provide customer and material data. Integration says its order mapping is ready, but no one has agreed who proves the end-to-end result. The project manager still reports the workstream as green.

YOUR 90-SECOND ANSWER

You are the SAP Lead. What will you do today, and who must own the result?

ASSESSOR PUSHBACK

The project manager says, “We already have a project organisation chart. Why create another matrix?”

CHANGED CONDITION

The business process owner is absent for five days. Who can accept criteria, and when would you escalate?

YOUR NOTES / DECISION - EVIDENCE - OWNER

Fictional scenario for assessment practice.

CASE 02 / DACI · NEGOTIATION

A pricing request meets the clean-core rule

THE SITUATION

A sales director wants a special discount calculation before the next release. The SD consultant says a custom enhancement is the fastest route. The architect warns that the change could increase upgrade and testing costs. The delivery manager has promised a date, but nobody has agreed who can approve an exception.

YOUR 90-SECOND ANSWER

How will you move this conflict to a defensible decision?

ASSESSOR PUSHBACK

The sales director asks, “Are you blocking revenue because of an architecture principle?”

CHANGED CONDITION

The workaround is legally unacceptable. What new constraint changes your recommendation?

YOUR NOTES / DECISION - EVIDENCE - OWNER

Fictional scenario for assessment practice.

CASE 03 / SAP SD / MM · CONFLICT

Stock exists, but the sales order cannot confirm

THE SITUATION

Customer service sees available stock in a warehouse report, yet a new sales order has no confirmed quantity. Sales blames MM for incorrect inventory. Logistics says the stock is physically present. The customer expects delivery tomorrow, and the discussion is becoming personal.

YOUR 90-SECOND ANSWER

How do you calm the situation and organise the investigation?

ASSESSOR PUSHBACK

The business user says, “I do not want a technical lesson. Can we deliver or not?”

CHANGED CONDITION

The stock is in quality inspection. What changes in your options and stakeholder discussion?

YOUR NOTES / DECISION - EVIDENCE - OWNER

Fictional scenario for assessment practice.

CASE 04 / SBI / SBII · FEEDBACK

The expert who silences the team

THE SITUATION

A senior consultant is technically strong and often rescues difficult defects. In three design reviews, the consultant interrupted a junior colleague before test evidence was presented. After the meeting, the junior colleague stopped raising concerns. A delivery manager suggests ignoring it because the senior person is hard to replace.

YOUR 90-SECOND ANSWER

What exactly would you say to the consultant, and what would you change in the team?

ASSESSOR PUSHBACK

The consultant responds, “I was only trying to save time. We have a deadline.”

CHANGED CONDITION

The behaviour continues after two direct feedback conversations. What is your next step?

YOUR NOTES / DECISION - EVIDENCE - OWNER

Fictional scenario for assessment practice.

CASE 05 / DELEGATION · MOTIVATION

Everything waits for the Lead

THE SITUATION

A capable SD consultant asks the Lead to approve every configuration detail. At the same time, the Lead receives incident questions, design requests and meeting invitations throughout the day. Two decisions are late, and the consultant says they feel they are not trusted.

YOUR 90-SECOND ANSWER

How do you delegate without losing control of delivery quality?

ASSESSOR PUSHBACK

The project manager says, “If something fails, you will still be responsible.”

CHANGED CONDITION

The consultant makes a poor decision inside the agreed boundaries. How do you respond?

YOUR NOTES / DECISION - EVIDENCE - OWNER

Fictional scenario for assessment practice.

CASE 06 / SAP MM / FI · PROBLEM SOLVING

Procurement and Finance argue over an invoice

THE SITUATION

A supplier invoice is for 100 units, while the purchasing team can see only 80 units received against the purchase order. Finance says the invoice cannot be processed as expected. Procurement says the missing 20 units are on the way and wants an immediate fix. Each team claims the other owns the problem.

YOUR 90-SECOND ANSWER

How would you separate process facts, SAP behaviour and responsibility?

ASSESSOR PUSHBACK

The procurement manager says, “Can we just change the tolerance so this invoice goes through?”

CHANGED CONDITION

The goods were received physically, but the SAP goods receipt was not posted. Who acts first?

YOUR NOTES / DECISION - EVIDENCE - OWNER

Fictional scenario for assessment practice.

CASE 07 / PLANNING · REPORTING

The status is green; the release is not ready

THE SITUATION

Go-live is in twelve days. The status report is green, but several high-impact defects remain open and test execution has slowed. An external interface owner has not confirmed its cutover support. The sponsor says the date cannot move because customers have been informed.

YOUR 90-SECOND ANSWER

How do you present the risk and make a decision possible?

ASSESSOR PUSHBACK

The sponsor asks, “Are you telling me to delay go-live?”

CHANGED CONDITION

Every critical defect is closed, but no full end-to-end test has passed. Is that enough?

YOUR NOTES / DECISION - EVIDENCE - OWNER

Fictional scenario for assessment practice.

CASE 08 / INTEGRATION · INCIDENT LEADERSHIP

An interface fails while teams trade blame

THE SITUATION

During a busy order-processing period, incoming sales orders stop appearing in S/4HANA. Sales says the middleware is down. Integration says the source system sends bad data. The business has no single view of how many orders are affected or whether resending them could create duplicates.

YOUR 90-SECOND ANSWER

What do you organise in the first 30 minutes?

ASSESSOR PUSHBACK

The business says, “Please resend everything now. We cannot lose these orders.”

CHANGED CONDITION

Only one customer is affected, but it is the largest customer. How does priority change?

YOUR NOTES / DECISION - EVIDENCE - OWNER

Fictional scenario for assessment practice.

CASE 09 / AI · GOVERNANCE

The business wants AI to release blocked invoices

THE SITUATION

An operations manager proposes an AI assistant that will read invoice exceptions and release blocked invoices automatically. The team expects faster processing, but nobody has specified the allowed actions, error cost, audit trail or when a human must decide. A product owner wants a working demo in two weeks.

YOUR 90-SECOND ANSWER

How would you design a useful first step without giving AI uncontrolled authority?

ASSESSOR PUSHBACK

The manager says, “If a human still has to approve it, where is the value?”

CHANGED CONDITION

The assistant works well on common cases but fails on rare high-value invoices. What changes?

YOUR NOTES / DECISION - EVIDENCE - OWNER

Fictional scenario for assessment practice.

CASE 10 / NEGOTIATION · EXECUTIVE COMMUNICATION

A sponsor adds three countries before Friday

THE SITUATION

The project is ready to test an initial sales process for one country. At a steering meeting, a sponsor asks to include three more countries in the same release. Local taxes, pricing and shipping rules have not been analysed. The sponsor calls the change “just copying configuration” and says there is no extra budget.

YOUR 90-SECOND ANSWER

What do you say in the meeting, and what do you do after it?

ASSESSOR PUSHBACK

The sponsor replies, “A Lead should find a way, not tell me what is impossible.”

CHANGED CONDITION

The extra countries become a legal requirement. How do you replan and communicate the change?

YOUR NOTES / DECISION - EVIDENCE - OWNER

Fictional scenario for assessment practice.

PART IV / REVIEW

Model answers

These are examples, not fixed scripts. A strong assessor will change one condition and ask whether your decision still works.

Compare your answer with the business outcome, evidence, options, risk, approval authority and next action.

MODEL ANSWER 01 / B2 SPEAKING

The UAT handoff nobody owns

ONE POSSIBLE RESPONSE

I would start from the missing deliverables, not from the organisation chart. I would list test data, mapping evidence, execution, defect triage and business acceptance. In a short meeting, I would assign one accountable person and one responsible owner for each item using RACI. The business process owner must confirm the acceptance criteria, while the technical teams own their checks. I would ask each owner to confirm the date and evidence of completion. Then I would update the plan and report that the status depends on these handoffs. A RACI matrix is useful here because the problem is missing responsibility, not a technical design decision.

WHAT MAKES THIS ANSWER STRONG

Notice the concrete deliverables, one A for each, business acceptance, evidence and an honest status update.

PRACTISE THE VARIATION

The business process owner is absent for five days. Who can accept criteria, and when would you escalate?

Now try the answer again without reading it.

MODEL ANSWER 02 / B2 SPEAKING

A pricing request meets the clean-core rule

ONE POSSIBLE RESPONSE

I would first confirm the business result and the real deadline. Then I would ask the architect and SD team to prepare options: standard pricing configuration, a supported extension if needed, and a temporary business workaround. We would compare delivery time, risk, maintenance and the effect on billing. I would use DACI to name one driver and the person authorised to approve the choice. I would recommend the simplest option that meets the requirement without creating unnecessary long-term risk. I would document the decision, the test evidence we need and the point when we must review it again. The goal is to protect revenue and system health together.

WHAT MAKES THIS ANSWER STRONG

Look for business interests, genuine alternatives, explicit authority, SAP impact and a recorded trade-off.

PRACTISE THE VARIATION

The workaround is legally unacceptable. What new constraint changes your recommendation?

Now try the answer again without reading it.

MODEL ANSWER 03 / B2 SPEAKING

Stock exists, but the sales order cannot confirm

ONE POSSIBLE RESPONSE

I would start with the delivery promise and give the business one clear owner for the answer. I would not assume that physical stock must be available for this sales order. We need to check the plant, storage and stock status, requirements, dates and the availability-check rules in this system. SD, inventory and possibly warehouse teams should compare the same material and document evidence together. I would separate confirmed facts from possible causes and set a short time for the investigation. Then I would explain the realistic delivery options to customer service. Only after we find the cause would I support a master-data, process or configuration change.

WHAT MAKES THIS ANSWER STRONG

Do not confuse stock visibility with ATP confirmation. Separate evidence, accountable communication and technical investigation.

PRACTISE THE VARIATION

The stock is in quality inspection. What changes in your options and stakeholder discussion?

Now try the answer again without reading it.

MODEL ANSWER 04 / B2 SPEAKING

The expert who silences the team

ONE POSSIBLE RESPONSE

I would speak with the consultant privately, not accuse them in the group. I would describe one clear situation: during the design review, the test explanation was interrupted before the evidence was shared. I would explain the impact: the team may miss defects and junior colleagues stop contributing. I would ask what the consultant intended and listen to the answer. Then I would agree on one visible change, such as hearing the full risk and evidence before challenging a proposal. In the next review, I would give all relevant people time to speak and check whether the behaviour has changed. Technical strength does not remove the responsibility to work well with others.

WHAT MAKES THIS ANSWER STRONG

Specific observation, impact, intent inquiry, future behaviour and follow-up. Avoid personality labels.

PRACTISE THE VARIATION

The behaviour continues after two direct feedback conversations. What is your next step?

Now try the answer again without reading it.

MODEL ANSWER 05 / B2 SPEAKING

Everything waits for the Lead

ONE POSSIBLE RESPONSE

I would keep accountability for the workstream but change how decisions are made. First, I would agree with the consultant on the result they own, the constraints and the evidence needed. I would give them authority to decide standard configuration details inside defined boundaries. Changes that affect architecture, other processes or major business risk would still come to me with options and a recommendation. We would have short review points rather than approval for every step. This gives the consultant room to develop while keeping important controls. I would also reduce my own work in progress and make escalation conditions clear. Delegation should increase ownership, not remove support.

WHAT MAKES THIS ANSWER STRONG

Distinguish accountability from personal approval of every task. Include guardrails and skill development.

PRACTISE THE VARIATION

The consultant makes a poor decision inside the agreed boundaries. How do you respond?

Now try the answer again without reading it.

MODEL ANSWER 06 / B2 SPEAKING

Procurement and Finance argue over an invoice

ONE POSSIBLE RESPONSE

I would review the purchase order history, goods receipts, invoice reference and the relevant invoice-verification settings before suggesting a change. We need to know whether goods-receipt-based invoice verification is active and why the invoice is blocked or treated differently in this process. I would ask Procurement to own the supplier and delivery facts, and Finance to own the accounting and payment controls. The SAP team would provide the system evidence and options. We should not change tolerances just to clear one case without understanding the financial risk. I would agree on the correct business action and record who will confirm the final document and account status.

WHAT MAKES THIS ANSWER STRONG

Avoid assuming every quantity mismatch behaves the same in every system. Separate business action, FI control and SAP evidence.

PRACTISE THE VARIATION

The goods were received physically, but the SAP goods receipt was not posted. Who acts first?

Now try the answer again without reading it.

MODEL ANSWER 07 / B2 SPEAKING

The status is green; the release is not ready

ONE POSSIBLE RESPONSE

I would not decide from a colour on the dashboard. I would show what has passed, what is still untested, the severity of open defects and the support dependency. I would run a short pre-mortem with the team: what failure could stop order entry, delivery or billing on the first day? For each material risk we need an owner, mitigation, contingency and trigger. I would prepare choices for the authorised go/no-go group, including the business consequences of proceeding or delaying. My recommendation would depend on agreed release criteria and evidence. I would communicate the uncertainty early, not wait until the night before cutover.

WHAT MAKES THIS ANSWER STRONG

Give facts, release criteria, options, risk ownership and decision authority. Never promise safety without evidence.

PRACTISE THE VARIATION

Every critical defect is closed, but no full end-to-end test has passed. Is that enough?

Now try the answer again without reading it.

MODEL ANSWER 08 / B2 SPEAKING

An interface fails while teams trade blame

ONE POSSIBLE RESPONSE

I would set one incident owner and a short update rhythm for the business. First, we need to understand the impact: affected order range, time window and whether orders are delayed or missing. The technical team should trace a small sample from source to middleware to SAP and find the first place where the expected state is wrong. We would check error messages, correlation references and processing status. Before replaying data, we must understand duplicate risk and the recovery method. I would separate immediate recovery from deeper root-cause work. Once the flow is restored, we would reconcile the orders and agree on monitoring and prevention.

WHAT MAKES THIS ANSWER STRONG

Prioritise containment, correlation, safe replay, reconciliation and clear business communication over blame.

PRACTISE THE VARIATION

Only one customer is affected, but it is the largest customer. How does priority change?

Now try the answer again without reading it.

MODEL ANSWER 09 / B2 SPEAKING

The business wants AI to release blocked invoices

ONE POSSIBLE RESPONSE

I would begin with the exact exception types, volume and business cost. We can first test an assistant that explains the mismatch, finds relevant evidence and proposes the next action. SAP remains the system of record, and release decisions follow the approved business controls. I would use historical or synthetic cases to measure accuracy, wrong recommendations and time saved. For a first pilot, a human should review the proposed actions, especially where payment and compliance are affected. Only after reliable results and formal approval would we consider narrowly controlled automation. I would also define logging, access rights and a clear way to stop or reverse an action when possible.

WHAT MAKES THIS ANSWER STRONG

Define measurable value, approval authority, audit evidence, security and failure handling; do not confuse recommendation with posting authority.

PRACTISE THE VARIATION

The assistant works well on common cases but fails on rare high-value invoices. What changes?

Now try the answer again without reading it.

MODEL ANSWER 10 / B2 SPEAKING

A sponsor adds three countries before Friday

ONE POSSIBLE RESPONSE

I would acknowledge the business reason for the request and make the missing information visible. Adding countries may affect tax, pricing, logistics, master data, integration and testing. I would not give an estimate before a short impact review. I would offer choices: keep the original release, add one country after clear acceptance criteria, or expand scope with an agreed change in date and capacity. For each choice I would explain risk and evidence needed. I would ask the authorised sponsor to confirm the priority and record the decision. My job is to find feasible options and explain their consequences, not to accept a promise we cannot support.

WHAT MAKES THIS ANSWER STRONG

Negotiate outcome rather than defend a fixed position; provide feasible options, scope impact and recorded commitment.

PRACTISE THE VARIATION

The extra countries become a legal requirement. How do you replan and communicate the change?

Now try the answer again without reading it.

PART V / MEMORY SHEET

Last-page rehearsal

Use these clear B2 sentences when you need a reliable way to start.

I would start by clarifying the business impact and the decision owner.

Before changing configuration, I would check the evidence.

The main trade-off here is delivery speed versus long-term risk.

Let us separate immediate recovery from root-cause investigation.

I would document the decision, its assumptions and the review point.

Final self-check

Outcome - Facts - Authority - Options - Owner - Evidence.

Further reading

Atlassian: RACI

Atlassian: DACI

Atlassian: Pre-mortem

Center for Creative Leadership: SBI / SBII

Harvard Program on Negotiation: BATNA

PERSONAL LAB

About the author

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Dzmitryi works across SAP logistics, Sales and Procurement, integration, master data and enterprise operations. His personal technical lab also explores practical AI and methods for managing complex business problems.

He maintains this site as an independent knowledge base for learning, experiments and reusable engineering practices. This guide helps SAP practitioners discuss decisions, coordinate work across teams and connect technical evidence with business outcomes.

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Independence and use

This is personal, non-commercial study material, not an official EPAM Systems or SAP publication. All project scenarios are fictional, not actual client accounts. System-specific SAP rules and decision authority require verification.

October 2026. Refer to the online Leadership Toolkit for updates.